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Introduction

The war between the US, Israel, and Iran in 2026 was one of the most significant geopolitical crises of our time. A careful examination of the roots of the conflict reveals that it cannot be viewed as a sudden escalation or an isolated incident. Rather, it stems from decades of political pressure, economic sanctions, covert operations, and strategic rivalry between Western powers and a regional player that is outside the West.

From the 1979 Islamic Revolution, Iran has followed a foreign policy focused on resisting Western influence and challenging the existing geopolitical order in the Middle East. The United States and its main regional ally, Israel, have consistently responded with efforts to contain this strategy.

This case study examines the thesis that the US-Israel conflict with Iran represents not a defensive response to an immediate security threat, but instead serves broader ambitions of world hegemony and regional dominion. This analyzes the systemic zero-sum game and the deep economic fallouts so that this analysis reveals the systemic conatics such as why does evident conflicts takes place, why not sensitive but strategic responses are taken by Iran?, what is the potential role of global powers like china/US? In addition to all these other forces seen in Gobal order.

1. Major Reasons Behind the U.S.-Israel War Against Iran

1.1 Historical Roots and Economic Containment

After the 1979 Iranian Revolution toppled a monarchy supported by Western powers, tensions began to take shape. A new government emerged - this time an Islamic Republic - and that shift rocked regional dynamics hard. From Washington's view, limiting Iran’s influence suddenly

became central. Over years, pressure built through penalties so wide they touched more than 1,500 people, businesses and industries by 2025 (World Bank, 2026). Oil flows shrank under these rules; once moving about 2.5 million barrels daily before 2017, shipments dipped below 1 million during several periods (IEA, 2025). In Tehran, such moves never felt neutral - they looked like long-term attacks on national control.

1.2 The 2026 Military Offensive

A sudden wave of attacks set off the conflict launched together by the United States and Israel at the start of 2026. In just one day, nearly nine hundred bombings struck across key sites: atomic research centers, army posts, command hubs, and high-level residences (Britannica, 2026). Alongside these explosions ran a hidden digital front. Before planes even took flight, unseen software intrusions had already been slipped into networks, tied to American operations. Out of nowhere, Cyber Command struck alongside Israel's Unit 8200, knocking out Iran's early-warning radars and cutting off key command links. Silent aircraft slipped through the sky - F-35s and B-2s among them - carrying weapons built to dive deep before exploding, tearing through hidden sites such as Fordow.

Iran turned on homebuilt air defenses like Bavar-373 and Khordad-15, along with Russian-made S-300 PMU2 units. Though some older slow-moving cruise missiles and fake targets were shot down - roughly one out of every six or seven - the flood of attacks plus jamming signals overloaded central control hubs. Operators shifted to acting alone by necessity when links failed under pressure. Such exact timing points toward careful advance setup instead of sudden reaction. Death tolls possibly above three thousand early on emerged quickly; buildings vital to daily life lay broken across regions (Business Insider, 2026). Questions grew fast between nations about whether force used matched threat level under global legal standards.

1.3 The Nuclear Narrative and Regional Competition

Still, Iran sticks to its word on global deals, letting IAEA inspectors come around when needed (IAEA, 2025). Because of this, some experts question why one nation faces constant watch while another keeps silent about bombs it never confirmed. Pressure from the West often points at nukes, yet actions go beyond just security concerns. Even so, influence through ties across Iraq,

Syria, Lebanon, and Yemen grows slowly, shaped by shifting loyalties. While officials abroad call these links dangerous, leaders in Tehran see them as survival tools against surrounding threats. Behind closed doors, moves are less about offense and more about holding ground under tightening circles. Despite claims of peace, outcomes keep leaning toward control rather than cooperation.

2. Iran's Responses: Resistance, Strategy, and Adaptation

2.1 Asymmetrical Warfare

Facing stronger enemies in tech and firepower, Iran builds its defense around surprise tactics instead of head-on fights. Missiles streak through the sky alongside pilotless planes, backed by digital attacks and split-up control systems. Early in the conflict, waves of strikes - more than three0 dozen combined - hit key outposts used by American and Israeli troops. By spreading risk across many tools, it aims to make victory too costly for foes without burning its own resources. High-end gear matters less when disruption hits harder.

2.2 Control of the Strait of Hormuz

Through the narrow waters of the Strait of Hormuz, Iran holds quiet power. When pushed by force, it slowed shipping lanes. With just a move at sea, Tehran whispered loud: more attacks mean costly ripples worldwide. A local clash suddenly pulled in distant economies (AP News, 2026).

2.3 Economic Diplomatic Resilience

Even with years of war troubles and tough international penalties - shrinking its economy by 12% from 2018 to 2024 (World Bank, 2026) - Iran held firm economically. Instead of relying on old

allies, it shifted course, building stronger commerce links with Beijing; by 2025, nearly one-third of its oil shipments went to China (IMF, 2026). On the world stage, Tehran painted these moves not as desperation but resistance - framing Western pressure as modern empire-building, a stance that quietly won nods from several developing countries.

3. Roles of the United Nations and Major Powers

3.1 United Nations Structural Limits

It turns out the United Nations struggles to calm things down in serious conflicts. Even though it asks for ceasefires, doing anything real gets blocked inside the Security Council. When big countries say no using their veto power, nothing moves forward. This setup lets influential nations ignore global rules without facing consequences.

3.2 Russia and China with their Strategic Role

Not one move made alone sits well with Russia, which pushes talks instead. Backing Tehran fits a pattern - standing against Western dominance without rushing into war zones. At the same time, Beijing moves mostly because of fuel needs. Before fighting broke out, it took in about 1.2 up to 1.5 million barrels daily from Iran, making around a tenth of its oil supply; much went to smaller private refineries avoiding global banking eyes. Inside UN debates, China’s envoy spoke sharply against attacks launched by force. Out of nowhere came strong words against using military power without following global rules, saying such actions could wreck economies in poorer nations. Though Beijing pushed a plan calling for peace and open sea routes right away, Washington blocked it - nothing new there, really showing how stuck the U.N. has become. Side by side, China and Iran have built something lasting through a deal meant to last decades, hinting at deeper changes worldwide as different powers step up where others once ruled alone.

3.3 India’s Pragmatic Neutralit

Out there among global powers, India walks a thin line. Because it needs oil from the Middle East. For India, staying neutral isn’t optional, it’s necessary. Historically, India relied on Iran for nearly 10% of its total crude requirements, purchasing upwards of 450,000 barrels per day before previous sanctions regimes forced a reduction. When ships stopped moving in 2026, alarms went off inside New Delhi. Suddenly, securing fuel became top priority. Addressing the UN General Assembly, India's External Affairs Minister stand with a neutral approach, stating, "We urge all parties to exercise maximum restraint. The weaponization of vital maritime corridors is an unacceptable escalation that disproportionately punishes the Global South." Behind closed doors, India's envoys used ties with the U.S. and Iran alike to win assurances for ships flying its flag. This approach reflect a practical stance - neutrality, prioritizing domestic economic stability and the protection of the 8.5 million Indian citizens working across Gulf countries.

4. Impact on Global Security

4.1 Regional Tensions Rise with Increased Military Presence

The conflict has destabilized the broader Middle East, significantly increasing the risk of a wider regional war involving non-state actors and proxy networks. Also, this crisis has resulted in the severe militarization of critical global infrastructure. The weaponization of maritime trade routes elevates the stakes of the conflict, ensuring it cannot remain geographically contained.

4.2 Nuclear Proliferation Risks

A major lasting danger lies in how easily more countries might start building nuclear weapons. When Iran feels constantly under threat, it could decide that going fully nuclear offers the strongest protection. This kind of move might push nearby nations in the Gulf to follow suit, one after another.

5. Impact on the Global Economy

5.1 Energy Market Disruptions and the Strait of Hormuz

Oil markets is started shaking when movement through the Strait of Hormuz disrupted. The Strait has a average daily flow of 20 million barrels of oil, which is 20% to 25% of global petroleum liquids consumption and also 20% of global liquefied natural gas (LNG) trade (IEA, 2025). Iran's restriction of this chokepoint triggered immediate market panic and removed massive supply volumes. Because of that, prices for Brent crude surged more than 30% percent which is heavily destabilizing global energy markets. (World Bank, 2026).

5.2 Disproportionate Exposure of Asian Markets

The energy shock has not impacted the globe equally. Approximately 84% of the crude oil shipped via the Strait of Hormuz head toward Asia. China, India, Japan abd South Korea combined take up nearly 69% of all crude oil moving through Hormuz. This sudden disruption heavily threatens the industrial sectors and economic stability of these specific nations, which lack the massive strategic petroleum reserves available to some Western countries.

5.3 Global Supply Chain and Agricultural Crises

The economic impact extends far beyond energy. About 30% of these fertilizer shipments crossing borders - like urea, made from chilled natural gas, move through that narrow sea route. When those shipments stopped, shockwaves hit farming economies worldwide, pushing food production much higher in price while hunger risks climbed fast. Also after the first attacks, the cost of LNG jumped sharply which spiked the price of urea more than double in less than a month. For developing nations whose are heavily dependent on these imports, the consequences making more trouble. In Sub-Saharan Africa, where fertilizer application rates are already the lowest globally, the sudden price spike forced millions of smallholder farmers to sharply reduce their

usage. Because of this shift, the UN Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) projected an 18% to 22% drop in staple crop yields, including maize and sorghum, across East Africa and the Sahel region for the 2026-2027 harvest cycle. Similarly, in South Asia, nations like Bangladesh and Sri Lanka faced severe fertilizer shortages during critical planting seasons, pushing domestic rice prices up by 45%. This fertilizer shock acts as a regressive tax, turning basic meals out of reach for the poorest global populations and pushing an estimated 40 million additional people into food insecurity. Also the developing countries, still struggling with post-pandemic inflation, this crisis added new pressure to them.

5.4 Inflation and Escalating Shipping Costs

Because of serious safety threats, major global logistics companies have been forced to suspend transits through the Strait of Hormuz and the Suez Canal. Rerouting commercial vessels around the Cape of Good Hope increases travel distances by up to 48% and transit times by 45% (UNCTAD, 2026). This logistical diversion is costing shipping firms an estimated $40 million to $50 million per week for burning extra fuel and incresed insurance plans. These massive extra costs are passed directly to international consumers, increasing global inflation and slowing global economic growth by an estimated 1.5 to 2 percentage points. (IMF, 2026).

Conclusion

The U.S.-Israel war on Iran is a major example that exposes deep structural crack in the international system. By analyzing the conflict beyond this war reveals the struggle over regional hegemony, sovereignty and the enforcement of Western strategic dominance. Also Iran’s military and economic responses showing the strength and a strategic moves in against of global giants.

At the same time, the frozen actions of the United Nations and the increased chaos in worldwide fuel and transport networks show how shaky the linked global system really is. The absolute fragility of this situation was demonstrated just hours before this case study's submission. While a temporary two-week ceasefire was brokered by China and Pakistan on April 8 to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, the agreement collapsed almost instantly. Because Israel was excluded from the negotiations, they rejected the terms and launched renewed strikes in Lebanon on the morning

of April 9. In immediate retaliation, Iran re-closed the Strait of Hormuz, and fresh, unclaimed airstrikes have already resumed within Iranian territory. This rapid breakdown proves that surface-level agreements cannot resolve deep-rooted hostilities when key players act unilaterally. In the end, this war accelerates the ongoing transformation of global power dynamics, shifting the world further toward a multipolar security architecture while underscoring the urgent need for equitable adherence to international law.

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